Graphic Design

Getting Your Files Print-Ready

Summary Notes

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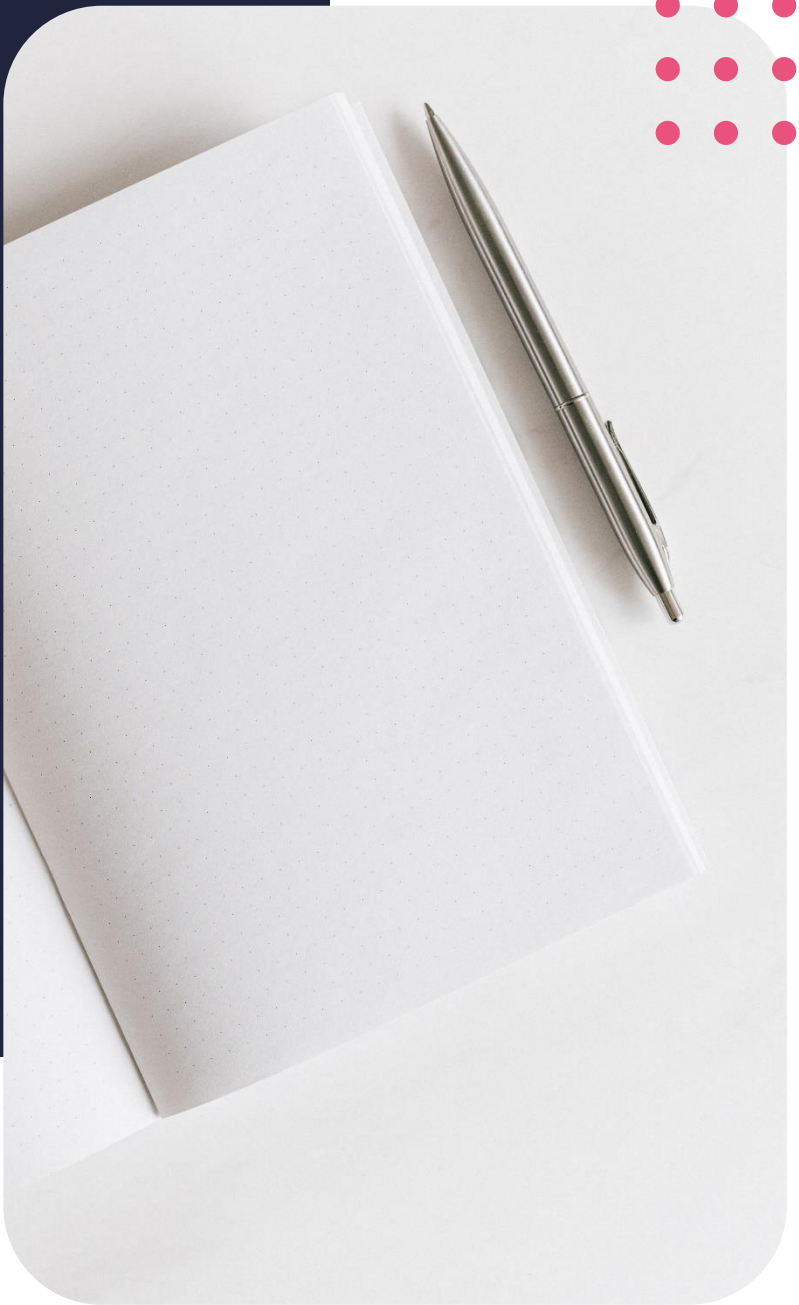

Introduction

We are one step closer to finish module 1 of your professional diploma in Graphic design!

InDesign is part of our final two lessons, and we will also look at how to get your files print-ready.

Did you know, a recent study revealed that almost all designers get addicted to some form of designing. So much so that even during a designer's off time, they still do designing instead of just sitting idle. What better way than to do what you love? Design helps to stimulate you creatively and the more you do it, the better you get at it.

Colour space

Our focus will be on another concept that is just as crucial as image resolution when preparing your design for print. We are delving into the two main colour spaces within a document. This concept links well with image resolution and should also be high on your list of basic design terminology. It is crucial to understand a document's colour space and getting this wrong, will literally cost you a lot – take it from me, I learned the hard way.

This term I am referring to is known as colour space and we will look at the two main colour spaces that are in use. Colour space refers to the colour mode an artwork is produced in.

Just as 72ppi is synonymous with digital artwork, so is RGB synonymous with digital artwork too. RGB is the abbreviation for red, green and blue which are the primary colours of light. Do you know what colour you would get if you added RGB together? – White. Which is why this colour space is often referred to as an additive colour model, since adding all these colours, produce white. Think about it this way: your device screen works with light, so it would make sense for it to use an additive colour model that also works with light.

If 300ppi is then synonymous with printing artwork, so then is CMYK colour space synonymous to printing as well. CMYK stands for cyan, magenta, yellow and black and is a subtractive colour model since when mixing these colour pigments, you get black... technically. You might ask why is black referred to as K? Well, K refers to black as the KEY colour since combining cyan, magenta and yellow colour pigments like ink or paint, do not result in a rich, full black, but rather a dark, muddy brown. The printing process then entails black to be added to make the colours of your printed image more vibrant with more contrast. And this is also why ink cartridges are usually produced in these colours!

If all this still confuses you, just know that RGB is the colour space you will save your digital artwork in and CMYK is the colour space you will save all your printed artwork in.

What do you think would happen if you selected the incorrect colour space when dropping your work off at the printers? Your colours will be distorted and will not look as what they did when you created your document. You also would have wasted a lot of valuable time and money as you will need to convert and send your artwork in for printing again. Therefore, your colour space is of crucial importance.

So, where exactly do you access and change your colour space in the Adobe programs? By default, Illustrator will select the colour space for you depending on what you state the document will be used for.

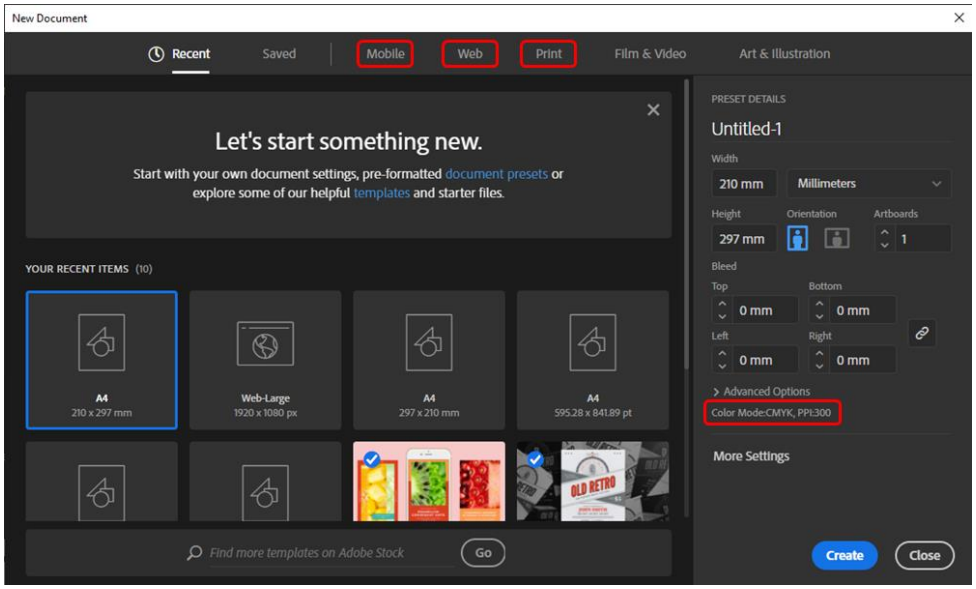

Image 1: Adobe Illustrator – accessing your colour mode to change your colour space

If you can recall our previous lessons, you will remember that we were able to state whether we were creating a mobile, web or print document. This function in Illustrator automatically changes to colour space for the intended purpose, which makes it relatively easy.

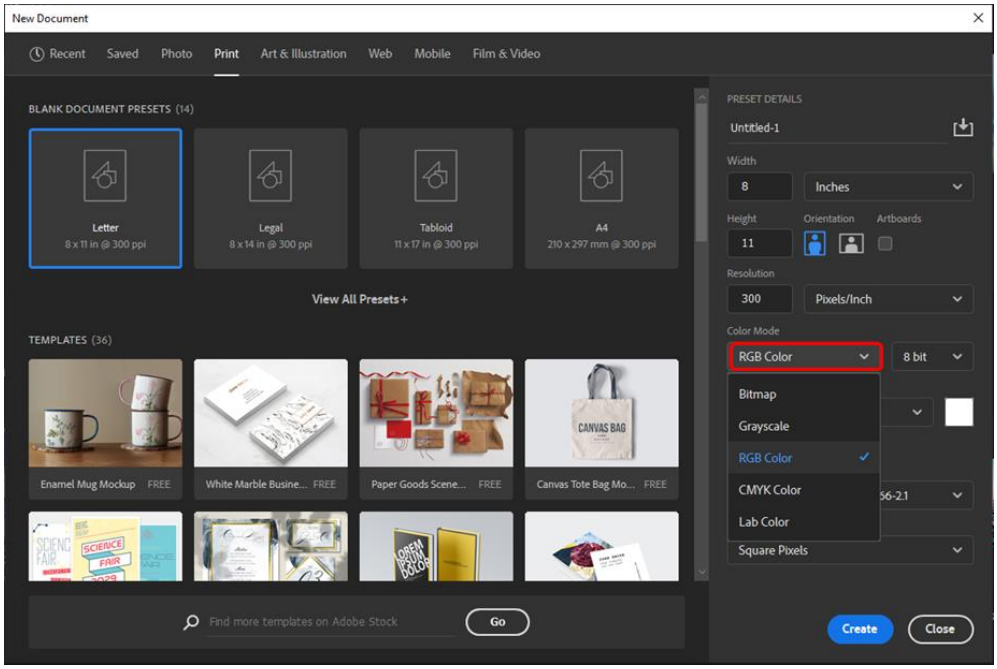

Image 2: Adobe Photoshop – accessing your colour mode to change your colour space

In Photoshop it works slightly different. You need to specify the colour mode in the right-hand panel when creating a new document. Don't worry too much about all the other colour modes now as you will 99% of the time make use of either CMYK or RGB.

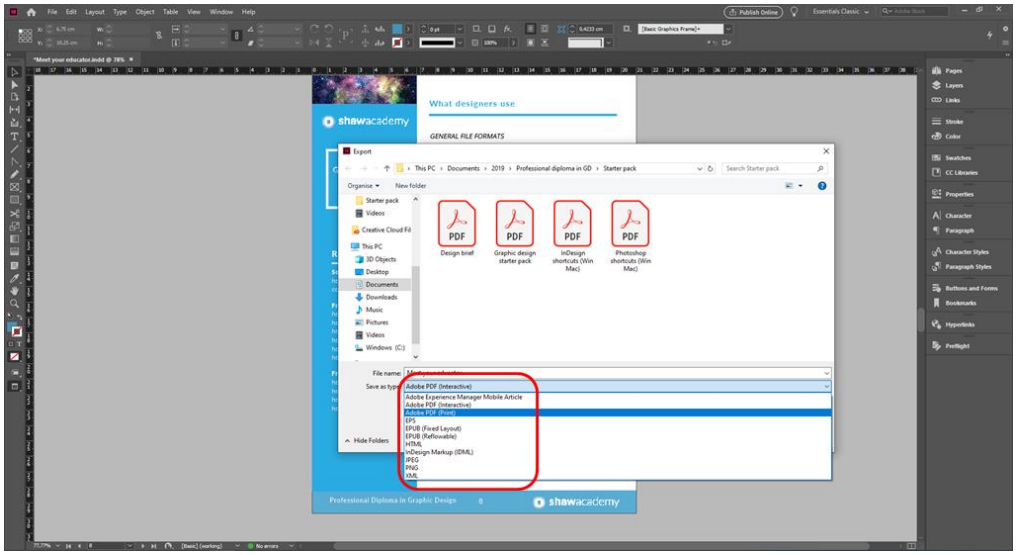

Image 3: Adobe InDesign – accessing your colour mode to change your colour space

In Adobe InDesign, which we will look at a bit later, the process works slightly different. You do not necessarily choose your colour space you will be working in at the start of creating a document but will rather export your document in the intended colour mode – it all depends on the purpose of your document since you might be creating a document that will be both printed and in digital format.

Getting your files print-ready

The first step in getting a file print-ready is to make sure that you are using the correct colour mode. If you are not sure about which colour mode to choose, PLEASE consult your printer as they will know exactly. Rather sound like a fool than spend a lot of money on something that could have been avoided.

I have found that sometimes, when printing a document on a basic deskjet printer – one of those printers you might have at home or at your work, the colour mode would not make that much of a difference but just in case, ALWAYS print a sample first, one in CMYK and another in RGB then simply compare the two and determine which one is more accurate.

Let's take a quick look at how to create a print-ready file by taking our works-everytime-flyer from Lesson 4.

Image 4: Print-ready document

Settings that need to be considered, especially when taking your artwork to a printer is making sure you have bleeds and cropmarks added.

Bleed

A bleed or trim marks, in design terms, refers to your design that exceeds, or goes beyond the edge of your sheet. As highlighted in blue on the example on the right.

This term bleed is difficult to understand if you have not had practical experience in it, but I will try explaining it as best I can. One thing you should know is that repro or printing companies do not necessarily print on sheets of paper, like your normal printer at work or home does. These printing companies normally have large rolls or large sheets of paper, where they will print multiple designs on one roll or large sheet. After the designs are printed, they move over to a guillotine or trimming machine that cuts the pages into the desired size. This has the risk of slightly misaligning the cutting, hence, a BLEED, which is normally 3mm or 1/16" is added so that you do not have a white, non-printed edge on your document. Think of it like your design needs to BLEED over the edge of your paper.

Cutline

The edge of your design is indicated on this example by our CUTLINE – which is the pink dashed line. The cutline is not printed but I only added it to this example to indicate the printing surface of our design.

Crop marks

Crop marks go hand in hand with your bleed in that these are simple lines that indicates where the page should be trimmed or cut by the guillotine or trimming machine. You will notice the crop marks indicated in black on the corners of the example here.

Margins

The margins indicated by the green dashed line simply refer to your safe area and you will make sure that designs that are not intended to get cut off do not exceed your margins. If you can recall from our lesson where we did the works-everytime-layout, you will remember that we added margins in the beginning before we even started with our design.

Before we head onto InDesign, I want to briefly show you how to add cropmarks to an Illustrator document. I will simply take parts of our works-everytime-layout we created in lesson 4. *(Refer to lesson video)*

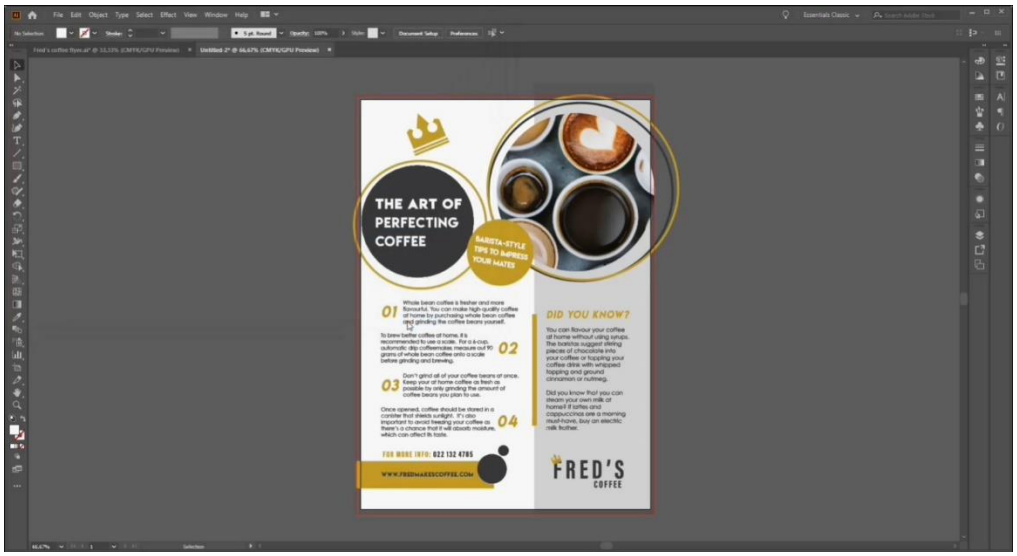

Image 5: Screenshot of getting your artwork print-ready in Illustrator

InDesign demo

Let the fun begin! We will investigate the last of our 3 programs you will learn in this course, InDesign is my absolute favourite and if you did not know this, where have you been?

I will start off by creating a new document and then introduce you to the essential interface. We will look at the function of our most important tools in the toolbar and other basic panels you should be aware of.

I will end off by showing you how to save and export your files for digital and printing purposes.

(Refer to lesson video)

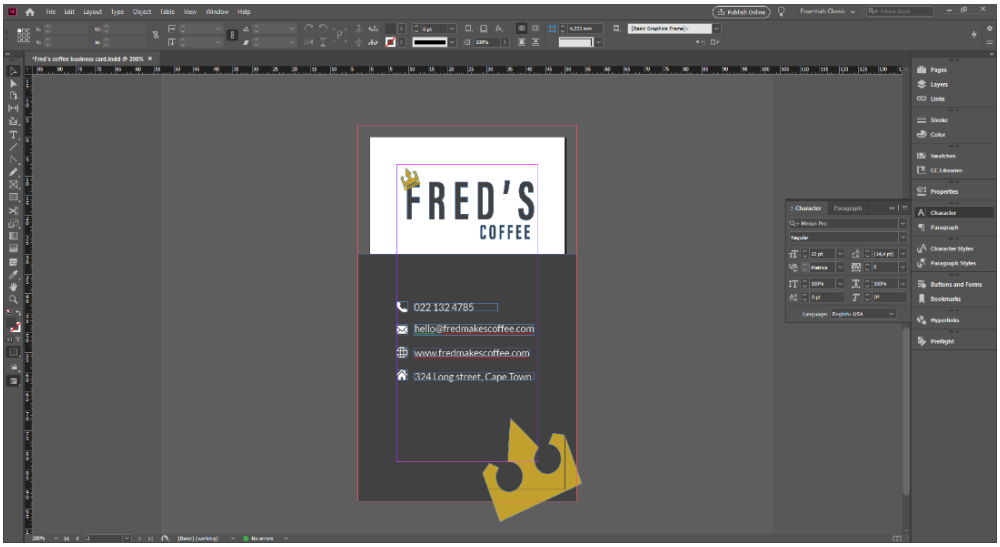

Image 6: Screenshot of designing a business card in InDesign

And with lesson 7 done, we literally only have one lesson left for module 1 and in lesson 8 we be designing a multi-page brochure in InDesign! I will also teach you the basics of typography and to understand that type is more than just communication. I will end off with some mistakes to avoid when you are looking at becoming a professional graphic designer.

Image 7:
Final business card design with cropmarks